The morning sun crept over Ravenholt, painting the concrete towers with a pale, dusty gold. The city, stretched across a shallow valley and along the edges of the salt flats, hummed with the sounds of life. Electric trucks hummed over cracked streets, weaving between pedestrians who hustled toward factories, offices, and schools. The air smelled faintly of salt brine and dust, a scent that clung to clothes and hair no matter how thoroughly you washed. Smoke spiraled from industrial stacks, meeting the low clouds like gray fingers pointing toward a sky that had forgotten what it meant to be clear.

Ravenholt was alive but tired. Every building, every streetlight, every bus stop bore the marks of long years of war, of paying off their debt, of just being. Panels patched with metal, faded paint, and flickering holoscreens. The city functioned, but barely and reluctantly. The old mag-rail trolleys rattled along their tracks above the streets, each vibration a reminder that the world had been rebuilt one too many times. People moved through it with quiet determination. Work, survive, repeat. As well on occasion, search for the light at the end of this dark tunnel.

From above, the city might have looked organized, almost clean. Blocks of apartments stood like dominoes, parks dotting the gray like islands of green. But down here, on the streets, the illusion faded. Children ran with backpacks too big for their shoulders, adults juggled comms devices and hover briefcases, and drones hummed overhead, delivering packages or performing inspections. The city did not pause for anyone, not even a seven-year-old boy weaving through the crowd.

Robby did not notice any of it consciously. He was too small, too busy adjusting his earbuds and making sure his backpack did not slip off one shoulder. But in a way, he noticed everything. Every crack in the sidewalk, every hum of a nearby drone, the way a mag-rail car rumbled over a warped panel, the faint smell of fried protein packs from a street vendor. It all became part of him, a catalog of detail that had served him in the three whole years he had been forced to go to school.

His parents had waved him off that morning with tired smiles. Both worked long shifts at a civilian engineering office in one of the northern industrial districts. Shifts started before sunrise and ended well after sunset. They kissed him quickly, one on the forehead, one on the cheek, and whispered, “Be good today.” That was it. That was the sum of parental guidance on a weekday morning. They made up for it on the weekend and he understood he had to be big to help out. Still, he looked forward to that kiss and hug and quick talk every morning and evening.

Robby watched them walk back toward the street as he turned toward the low-slung school building a block away. Ravenholt Primary School sat squat and gray, fenced in by low metal rails and patches of ground that blatently refused to be anything but desert sand regardless of effort. Once, it might have been sleek and white, modern enough to impress visitors. Now, it looked practical, patched, worn, a reflection of the city itself. Holo-screens blinked at the entrances, displaying rotating educational content: vocabulary words, planetary maps, the solar system map and it’s twin stars, reminders about hygiene, and occasional messages about Nemicorp separatists in the outer colonies.

The hallway inside smelled faintly of synth-food and cleaning solvent. Children shuffled past lockers, earbuds in, backpacks dragging. Some laughed in hushed tones, others walked silently, eyes forward, tapping notes into their OmniPads. Robby weaved between them, finding his desk near the center of the room. It was a modular design. Plastic and metal molded together, a tablet slot, a small cubby for books. He sat, slide his bag into the slot under his seat, and pulled out a notebook, flipping it open to a blank page.

The teacher’s holo-projection flickered at the front of the classroom, cameras in the corners sliding back in forth keeping an eye on everyone. A smiling woman in a crisp, bright uniform appeared, her face almost unnervingly calm and perfect. Her voice carried clearly across the classroom. Robby often wondered how she saw them, because students got called out all the time so he knew that she did. But he just couldn’t figure out how the ghost did it.

"Good morning, students. This morning we continue our lesson on the rise of our beloved United Earth government. So set your OmniPads to record, but rember to take notes as well."

The room went quiet. Most of the children tapped at their tablets, eyes forward. Robby didn’t have a slate so was one of the few who actually took notes, but he couldn’t help but to glance out the window. Beyond the low fence of the schoolyard, the city sprawled, humming with its endless routines. Electric trucks and cars zipped by, drones traced patterns overhead, and smoke curled lazily from distant stacks.

The holo-screen shifted to a rotating map of the solar system. Tiny red dots marked human colonies: Mars City, Callisto Hub, Europa Station. Lines of white traced the common trade routes of continuous-thrust engines, like veins pumping life through humanity’s skeleton. Beyond Saturn, faint markers indicated the brown dwarf star and its five planets. Nemicorp controlled them all, colonies fortified, off-limits to ordinary UE citizens.

"After the collapse of the United States nearly two centuries ago," the teacher said, "humanity united under the Core. Our civilization rose from the ashes of the old nation-states, bringing order, efficiency, and equality. Starfire crystals, integrated with fusion technology, enabled continuous-thrust engines. These engines finally made colonization of the solar system possible.”

The holographic teacher smacks the desk with a ruler. A sharp bang echoed. “Pay attention, you will be testing on this and getting good grades is important to your future and removes some of your debt. Continuing on. The starfire engines finally made realistic colonization of the solar system possible. Now the source of these crystals could only be found around the Nemesis Star, bonus points on the test if anyone can explain why the star bears that name. Anyone?"

The holographic teacher waited for a response, being projected to hundreds of classrooms at the same time, took a sip of water and continued. “No points then, continuing on. One corporation, called Nemicorp, started taking control over most of the corporations that operated in the collection and refinement of these crystals. Then started escalating the price. The UE opposed this so laid down a tax, one that could only be reduced if they lowered the price. After several years of arguing back and forth and refusal to pay the allotted taxes, the UE sent tax collectors in. They were all shot down, starting the UE-Nemicorp war some 85 years ago in March of 2177.”

“Nemicorp has been successful in their war to this point primarily due to their complete control over the Starfire crystals. Mars and the asteroid belt are the current fighting grounds that the UE are pushing back on. Beyond Saturn, Nemicorp’s reach is total for now. Their five planets that orbit the brown dwarf star. They refuse cooperation and threaten peace. Your generation must understand the stakes."

Robby traced one of the lines with his finger, imagining a tiny ship zipping along it, leaving a glowing trail. He thought about the books he had read, the scraps of tech he had tinkered with, the little rockets he had tried to build in his bedroom. He wanted to be an engineer someday. He wanted to design ships, big ships, small ships, and one day build a ship of his own, strong enough to reach the brown dwarf’s colonies. Adults said it was impossible. Adults said a lot of things were impossible and had stopped even trying. Robby had decided he would try anyway.

The teacher’s expression shifted, serious, authoritative. "But not all groups accepted the United Earth’s leadership. Nemicorp separatists in the outer colonies refused to participate in the shared burden of society. Their defiance threatens peace. Your generation must understand why cooperation is essential to continue our way of life."

Other children nodded, dutifully taking notes. Robby did not write that part down. The words felt like a story someone else was telling, a story that did not quite match the edges he could see, the cracks between truth and message. Instead his pencil hovered, then he doodled tiny spaceships in the margin, leaving trails of fire behind them as if they were escaping, leaving the lesson behind.

The bell rang, a sharp metallic clang that bounced down the hall. Children surged from their desks, spilling into the corridors like water through a broken dam. Robby grabbed his bag, weaving past taller kids, earbuds still dangling, eyes scanning for a familiar face.

He spotted Jalen near the edge of the playground, a boy about his age, lean and quick, always bouncing on the balls of his feet like he was ready to run at any moment. Jalen waved, grinning with the gap where his front tooth had been knocked loose last week.

"Hey, Robby!" Jalen shouted, already darting toward the metal playground structure. "You ready to lose today?"

Robby shook his head, a grin tugging at his lips. "Not a chance," he said. He dropped his bag by the fence and sprinted after him, sneakers kicking up small clouds of dust from the sand-strewn yard.

They ran through the old, scratched metal frame of the jungle gym, hopped over concrete blocks, and kicked a scuffed ball toward a patch of open dirt. It wasn't much, just the scraps of play equipment the school could afford, but to Robby it felt enormous, a private world where the rules could be whatever he and Jalen made them.

"You think they'll ever let us build real hover sleds for recess?" Jalen asked, panting after a long sprint.

Robby laughed. "They'll say it's impossible. Adults always do. But you know what? They never even try. I'm going to build one anyway."

"Yeah? Really?" Jalen's eyes widened.

"Not just fly around the school," Robby said, crouching to pick up a scrap of wire and a bent spring from the playground floor. "I want to build a ship that can reach the colonies past Saturn. Maybe even the brown dwarf system. Five planets out there, all Nemicorp. I'll go see them. I'll build it myself."

Jalen laughed. "You're crazy. But I like crazy. Can I help?"

"You can try," Robby said with a smirk. He tossed him the spring, which Jalen caught and immediately started fiddling with, twisting it and bending it in ways Robby would never have tried. Together, they worked like a little engineering team, imagining impossible contraptions from scraps and dust, building worlds in their minds even if nothing physically changed.

Around them, other kids played tag, kicked balls, or raced drone pods that barely hovered at all. Robby paid little attention. Break time was the only moment in the day when he could really be himself. No lessons, no lectures, no giant red numbers ticking on his hand from the debt chip. Just him, Jalen, and the possibilities of things they could build, the things they could imagine.

When lunch arrived, it was served as uniform trays: nutrient protein packs, a small fruit gel, and recycled water in sealed pouches. Robby held out his hand, pressing the embedded debt chip against the reader. A quiet beep sounded. Numbers scrolled across the screen, far too large for him to fully comprehend, billions in debt already, passed down from parents, grandparents, and distant ancestors. The lunch cost him five more dollars, and the chip added it to the staggering total. The numbers meant nothing to Robby. They were just numbers. The beep confirmed he could eat, and that was enough.

After lunch, mathematics class began. Robby loved math. He loved numbers, equations, patterns, and solving problems. He loved figuring things out and imagining how to build them himself. He scribbled calculations in the margin of his notebook, diagrams of engines and thrusters, imagining the parts of ships he would someday construct. Numbers and patterns were his way of making order in a world that felt chaotic.

The teacher explained multiplication grids and probability charts, showing examples with orbital paths and fuel calculations. Robby's eyes lit up. He imagined designing ships with these calculations, making them sleek and strong, capable of running long missions without human error. Math was a language adults said they understood. Robby understood it too. He would speak it better than anyone when he grew up.

When the school day ended, the children spilled into the streets once more. Parents emerged from apartment blocks, picking up children, sometimes waving from hover cars, sometimes too busy to notice who left or who lingered. Robby's parents were in the latter category. Their apartment awaited him, quiet and functional. Meals prepared earlier in the day, tidied rooms, a small corner of toys and books, but not much else.

Robby took off his shoes, dropped his bag, and opened his notebook again. On the page were dozens of tiny ships, dots of fire trailing behind, weaving through planets, skimming over orbital stations. In his mind, they were not just doodles. They were hope, autonomy, a sense of agency he had not yet realized he needed to cultivate.

As the evening light faded, Ravenholt hummed on, indifferent. Smoke still spiraled, electric trucks still rumbled, and the city did not pause for a small boy, or for anyone else. But inside his apartment, Robby was already learning the lessons the adults did not teach. He learned to notice, to tinker, to trust himself, and to survive in a world that often forgot he existed.